

Book Difficulty Levels

How should teams choose what to translate? First, trainers and leaders should consider whether translation has already begun in this language, or whether there is content in a similar language that they have been given permission to revise. For a training workshop, trainers often choose an easier book so that new translators will be encouraged by their progress. They may choose a book that is shorter, so the team can finish the entire draft quickly. They may choose a book that is not difficult, so the team can focus on learning the Eight Steps process without facing complex decisions about the translation.

After training, the leadership team will choose when (in what sequence) to translate each book. They should consider:

- What does the church community want to be translated?
- How experienced is the translation team?
- How much Biblical content has been translated into this language?

After noting which books have no previous usable work and must be translated from the very beginning, they should consider each book's difficulty level.

Remember, translation is a skill that grows with experience.

Because translation is a skill that grows, it is wise to start translating content that is less complicated so that the translators can learn the skill while translating something simple.

Usually, books that have more abstract, poetic, and theologically loaded terms and ideas are more difficult to translate. Books that are more narrative and concrete are generally easier to translate. Here is a chart of suggested book difficulty levels. Level 1 is the simplest, and level 4 is the most difficult.

	(chs.) Level 1	(chs.) Level 2	(chs.) Level 3	(chs.) Level 4
New Testament	24 Luke	28 Matthew	21 John	16 Romans
	28 Acts	16 Mark	16 1 Corinthians	6 Galatians
	1 Philemon	6 1 Timothy	13 2 Corinthians	6 Ephesians
		4 2 Timothy	5 1 Thessalonians	4 Colossians
		3 Titus	3 2 Thessalonians	13 Hebrews
		5 James	1 Jude	5 1 Peter
		1 2 John	4 Philippians	3 2 Peter
		1 3 John		5 1 John
		22 Revelation		
Old Testament	(chs.) Level 1	(chs.) Level 2	(chs.) Level 3	(chs.) Level 4
	24 Joshua	50 Genesis	27 Leviticus	42 Job
	21 Judges	40 Exodus	31 Proverbs	150 Psalms
	4 Ruth	36 Numbers	12 Ecclesiastes	66 Isaiah
	31 1 Samuel	34 Deuteronomy	8 Song of Songs	52 Jeremiah
	24 2 Samuel		5 Lamentations	48 Ezekiel
	22 1 Kings		12 Daniel	
	25 2 Kings		14 Hosea	
	29 1 Chronicles		3 Joel	
	36 2 Chronicles		9 Amos	
	10 Ezra		1 Obadiah	
	13 Nehemiah		7 Micah	
	10 Esther		3 Nahum	
	4 Jonah		3 Habakkuk	
			3 Zephaniah	
			2 Haggai	
			14 Zechariah	
			4 Malachi	